



Photographs by HARVINDER SINGH

Engine
2,999cc 6-cyl turbo petrol
Power 380bhp
Max torque 500Nm
Gearbox 9-speed automatic
Price Rs 1.15 crore (ex-showroom)



it the unmistakable GLE look. The 450 also gets new 20-inch AMG design alloy wheels. At the rear, the tail-lamps retain the shape, but there are redone lighting elements that look quite elegant. In terms of changes to the GLE's looks, Mercedes-Benz has done quite a good job of retaining the imposing yet relaxed look that enhances the SUV's road presence, which it already has tonnes of considering the dimensions.

The GLE's cabin has been the benchmark in the segment when it comes to luxury, comfort and tech, and with the new one too, not much has changed. So, you get the same layout with the imposing dual 12.3-inch displays. The quad aircon vents now get a new brushed metal surround. The biggest change for the cabin has to be the steering wheel, which has been lifted from the S-Class and comes with capacitive touch buttons. The front seats come with fully electric adjustability as well as heating and cooling, while the rear seats offer electric adjustability, although limited. The GLE comes loaded to the brim with various features, including a Burmester audio system, 4-zone climate control, rear window blinds, panoramic sunroof, air purifier and 100W fast charging Type-C ports. Mercedes-Benz has also added the transparent bonnet feature, which stitches a view of the under-bonnet as the car moves at slow speeds, useful to avoid obstacles while off-roading.

Powering the GLE 450 is a 3.0-litre inline six turbo petrol engine, which makes 380bhp and 500Nm mated to a 9-speed automatic transmission. For 2023, Mercedes-Benz has added a 48V integrated starter motor, which adds 20bhp and 200Nm of torque to all three powertrains of the GLE. The motor is extremely refined and has quite a bit of grunt when pushed hard, dispatching a 0-to-100 kmph sprint in 5.6 seconds, thanks in part to the electric boost of 200Nm. The SUV is very nimble for its size and easy to drive around, even in heavy traffic. A special mention here for the air suspension system with adaptive dampers, which absorbs undulations and speed breakers irrespective of speed, with very little filtering into the cabin, and also allows the driver to adjust the ride height manually.

The GLE is costlier than before, with prices starting at Rs 96.4 lakh and going up to Rs 1.15 crore (ex-showroom), which puts it on the pricier end compared to its primary rivals. But the GLE also defines what customers need and aspire for in this segment. It shouldn't be a surprise if the new car also becomes a volume seller for Mercedes-Benz in India, much like its predecessors. ■